

severe lagging of the Internet connection, and will force you to restart Windows at the risk of losing unsaved data.

To exploit weaknesses on your system, a hacker first has to learn what software you run. Data is exchanged from your PC through ports. Figuring out which ports are open and what kind of data they accept gives a good clue about your system. Port scanners are often used by attackers to find out whether a backdoor is running and if it accepts connections to your system. Firewalls close and lock ports that are not required and open them only when required. Hence, with a firewall running, it becomes difficult for a cracker to fingerprint your system.

Many users suffer due to backdoors. These software accept connections and allow anyone to take complete control of your system and all your data. Backdoors are difficult to detect unless their nature is already known, and firewalls can help by blocking all ports except those specifically opened for trusted applications.

Using Tiny Personal Firewall

Firewalls are available at varying prices, some even free. Let's have a look at how to install and configure Tiny Personal Firewall (TPF, www.tinysoftware.com), a firewall that doesn't hog system resources and runs quite fast. Installation and configuration is also fairly straightforward and the level of protection is appreciable.

Upon installation, TPF will be active and will scan your PC for potential weaknesses and existing Trojans. With default settings, the firewall is set to medium security with pre-set filter rules. The firewall will throw dozens of alerts the first few times it runs, to learn what network transactions to allow and what to block. The more network applications you run, the more alerts you'll see until TPF has built its database of allow and deny rules.

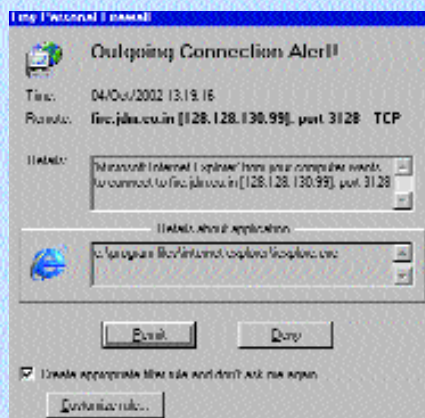
Backup Genie 1.5, No Hands Backup 2.0, SecurDat 2.1 Pro, Active@ Partition Recovery, FILERECOVERY for Windows, GetDataBack for FAT, PC Inspector File Recovery, Stellar Phoenix 8.0 Data Recovery Software, Zero Assumption Recovery, Advacrypt Suite 3.3.40s, Crypto-Lock 2.01, DPcrypto 1.05, PGP 7.03, Agnitum Outpost Firewall, Sygate Personal Firewall 5.0.1137, Tiny Personal Firewall 2.0.15

Find them on the Mindware CD



When prompted, check the option to create the appropriate rule and click Permit to allow the connection.

When you run TPF with the Internet connection on for the first time, you should disable all the Internet software. This way, you can identify any software



Allow only connections that you authorise

that tries to automatically connect from your computer without your knowledge. Start each program one by one, and allow each one as it tries to connect to the Net. It is a better practice to wait till the software reports a connection failure, and then re-attempt connecting after granting it access. This way, you increase the chances of preventing spyware from sending data out from your machine.

Right-click the TPF icon in the system tray and click Firewall Administration to enable or disable the firewall and access advanced configuration options. You can add or delete trusted address groups and set up filter rules. A filter rule lets you define the protocols (UDP, HTTP, etc) used, the ports through which access should be allowed, the applications allowed and when the rule should be valid. TPF also displays a dynamic list of open connections.

Permanent Internet access through cable and optical fibre connections are on the rise. It is very important that you use a firewall on such connections, as the PC is almost always on the same IP address. If you are not using the Net connection when the PC is connected, you can set the firewall to shut off all Internet transfer.

There are a number of ways you could lose data—through accidental deletion, hardware failure or malicious intent. But if you've backed up important data and secured it the correct way, you'll never face a data disaster. ■

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Encryption Tools

Crypto-Lock

www.rtsoftware.org

Crypto-Lock is a free file encryption program. The password you enter for encryption is stored within the file, but undergoes various processes to prevent it from being cracked. Also, even if you use the same password every file, random values are used for encryption, making it that much more difficult to crack.

Advacrypt Suite

www.advacrypt.cjb.net

Advacrypt Suite is a strong encryption application. The software supports all Windows versions and is free for personal use.

DPcrypto

www.dpaehl.de

This is a high security encryption program that supports several encryption algorithms.

This program is giftware—you can make a donation to the developer or offer to translate it to other languages.

Anti-virus Tools

F-Secure Anti-Virus

www.f-secure.com

F-Secure Anti-Virus regularly downloads anti-virus definitions transparently and is available in several versions for home and corporate networks. For offices, the corporate version allows management of anti-virus across the network from a central server, a very useful feature for administrators. You can also sign up to receive real-time security alerts from the F-Secure team.

Norton AntiVirus

www.symantec.com

Norton AntiVirus provides reliable protection against application viruses of various kinds, document viruses and even e-mail worms. Security alerts from the Symantec taskbar keep you abreast with the latest breakthroughs.

Firewalls

Sygate Personal Firewall

www.sygate.com

Free for personal use, Sygate Personal Firewall is pretty good at protecting your PC from hackers, Trojans and DoS attacks. It creates detailed logs of network traffic and keeps information on your PC safe and private.

Agnitum Outpost Firewall

www.agnitum.com

A personal firewall for Windows, Outpost Firewall prevents threats from cookies, banner ads, e-mail viruses, spyware, crackers, adware and other Internet dangers. It sports a plug-in architecture, making it highly scalable.